

screen. Up until then, using a computer involved writing a program, so the ability to directly create shapes without any computing expertise was seen as a step towards bringing the user closer to the computer. Sketchpad had obvious applications in the field of computer aided design, and also introduced many concepts like object oriented programming, memory management for objects on the screen, and GUI-related aspects like zooming and interacting with objects. Sketchpad influenced the GUIs that came after it.

June: ASCII Standardises Things

The American Standard Code for Information Interchange (ASCII) was introduced. It was a collaborative effort between the US government and the computer industry. The aim was the standardisation of the different character codes that were being used. Till then, each computer maker had a proprietary code, and the transfer of data required the use of translation tables. The ASCII code consists of 128 unique combinations of ones and zeroes, with each sequence representing a letter of the alphabet, an Arabic numeral, an assortment of punctuation marks and symbols, or a function such as a carriage return. The chief designer of the code was Bob Bemer.

“Hypertext”

The term “Hypertext” is coined by Ted Nelson. He was considering a system to record and organise his thoughts and arrived at the concept of a mass of information linked to each other. He visualised a “Docuverse,” where information is available and never deleted, and people can access any part of it by following links. Navigation, hence, would be non-linear, and subject to the choices of the user. The concept influenced people like Tim Berners-Lee, the creator of the World Wide Web—which is one implementation of Nelson’s vision!